SPECIMEN MATERIAL

FUNCTIONAL SKILLS LEVEL 2
ENGLISH
(8725)

Component 2 Writing

Mark scheme

Version 1.0

Mark schemes are prepared by the Lead Assessment Writer and considered, together with the relevant questions, by a panel of subject teachers. This mark scheme includes any amendments made at the standardisation events which all associates participate in and is the scheme which was used by them in this examination. The standardisation process ensures that the mark scheme covers the learners' responses to questions and that every associate understands and applies it in the same correct way. As preparation for standardisation each associate analyses a number of learners' scripts. Alternative answers not already covered by the mark scheme are discussed and legislated for. If, after the standardisation process, associates encounter unusual answers which have not been raised they are required to refer these to the Lead Examiner.

It must be stressed that a mark scheme is a working document, in many cases further developed and expanded on the basis of learners' reactions to a particular paper. Assumptions about future mark schemes on the basis of one year's document should be avoided; whilst the guiding principles of assessment remain constant, details will change, depending on the content of a particular examination paper.

Further copies of this mark scheme are available from aqa.org.uk

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Level of response marking instructions

Level of response mark schemes are broken down into levels, each of which has a descriptor. The descriptor for the level shows the average performance for the level. There are marks in each level.

Before you apply the mark scheme to a learner's answer, read through the answer and annotate it (as instructed) to show the qualities that are being looked for. You can then apply the mark scheme.

Step 1 Determine a level

Start by reading the whole of the learner's response and then, using the mark scheme level descriptors and the standardisation scripts, place the response in the level which it matches or best fits.

When assigning a level you should look at the overall quality of the answer and not look to pick holes in small and specific parts of the answer where the learner has not performed quite as well as the rest. If the answer covers different aspects of different levels of the mark scheme you should use a best fit approach for defining the level.

Step 2 Determine a mark

Once you have assigned a level you need to decide on the mark. The exemplar materials used during standardisation will help. There will be an answer in the standardising materials which will correspond with each level of the mark scheme. This answer will have been awarded a mark by the Lead Examiner. You can compare the learner's answer with the example to determine if it is the same standard, better or worse than the example. You can then use this to allocate a mark for the answer based on the Lead Examiner's mark on the example.

You may well need to read back through the answer as you apply the mark scheme to clarify points and assure yourself that the level and the mark are appropriate.

Content descriptors in the mark scheme are provided as a guide for examiners in exemplifying the skills descriptors for the particular task.

An answer which contains nothing of relevance to the question must be awarded no marks.

Spelling, punctuation and grammar (SPaG)

When applying the SPaG mark schemes, the following punctuation, grammar and modality device examples are those stated in the specification subject content for level 2. They are not all expected to be present in each response but to be referred to as a guide along with the standardisation scripts.

	Examples
Punctuation	colons, commas, inverted commas, apostrophes and quotation marks
Grammar and Modality devices	subject-verb agreement, consistent use of a range of tenses, definite and indefinite articles to express probability or desirability

1 You have received the following leaflet from your local council:

Write an email to Ashraf responding to the council's request. Your email should be approximately 150 to 200 words.

Remember to:

- plan your answer
- use correct spelling, punctuation and grammar
- write clearly and effectively.

[6 marks]
[+ 3 marks for SPaG]

Writing composition	
Marks	Skills Descriptors
5 - 6	• Fit-for-purpose response, with an appropriate level of development to engage the reader. Appropriate register (tone). • Appropriate formatting and length. • A range of simple and complex words/phrases are used correctly. • Variety of sentence structures, including complex sentences used correctly. • Clear and logical sequencing of points in text. Appropriate level of detail for the purpose.
3 - 4	• An acceptable response, with some attempt to engage the reader, but little development. Attempts at setting an appropriate register (tone), but not always sustained. • Acceptable (though not entirely correct) formatting. • Simple words/phrases are used correctly. • Some variety of sentence structures. • Some attempt to sequence logically, though not consistently. Level of detail is not necessarily appropriate (too long/short).
1 - 2	• A partial response to the task. No clear attempt to engage the reader. • Limited, if any, attempt to control format, length or text structure. • Some simple words are used correctly. • No attempt to set/maintain an appropriate tone. Sentence structures convey little, if any, meaning. • No attempt at logical sequencing and level of detail is inappropriate.
0	Nothing written worthy of credit.

Spelling, punctuation and grammar	
Marks	Skills Descriptors
3	Quality of SPaG supports clear meaning. • Spelling – including some specialist words – is sufficiently correct to convey meaning. • Sentence demarcation is correct and a range of other punctuation is mostly correct. Markers to ensure smooth and efficient reading are provided. • Few grammatical errors and modality devices are used appropriately.
2	SPaG does not detract substantially from the general meaning being conveyed. • Most common/simple words are spelled correctly. • Sentence demarcation is correct and other punctuation is sometimes correct, with some markers to support reading. • Grammatical errors are present and some modality devices are incorrect.
1	SPaG errors detract from meaning. • A few examples of conventional spelling. • Little evidence of correct punctuation. • Numerous grammatical errors.
0	Nothing written worthy of credit.

2 You are a reporter from the Wickby Post, a local newspaper.

You have visited Carroll's Fitness Centre and Gym and made the following notes:

Write an article for the local newspaper about the new Fitness Centre and Gym, including any strengths and weaknesses you found.

Remember to:

- plan your answer
- use correct spelling, punctuation and grammar
- write accurately in sentences and paragraphs.

[12 marks]
[+ 9 marks for SPaG]

Writing composition	
Marks	Skills Descriptors
10 - 12	• Clearly fit-for-purpose and audience. • Appropriate format and length. • Precise use of a range of sentence structures, including complex sentences. • Precise use of a range of appropriate words and phrases, including specialist ones. • Appropriate tone is set and maintained. • Logically sequenced, with each paragraph contributing to overall impact. • Sufficient detail to give the reader the information s/he needs, whilst maintaining the reader's attention.
7 - 9	• Adequate for purpose and audience. • Acceptable format, though possibly slightly too long/short. • Appropriate sentence structures. • Uses a range of appropriate words and phrases, including specialist ones, generally correctly. • Tone not consistently appropriate. • Paragraphs are used to support clarity, but not necessarily for overall effect. • Appropriate level of detail to convey key points.

4 - 6	• Meaning is conveyed, but not clearly fitting the purpose of the task. • Format is clear, but not necessarily appropriate. Might be too long/short. • Uses a range of words and phrases, with some attempt to use specialist ones – but sometimes incorrectly. • Some awareness of appropriate tone. • Some attempt at paragraphing/sequencing of ideas, but not sustained. • Key points are not clear.
1 - 3	• An attempt to respond to the task, but little, if any, awareness of audience/purpose. • Little, if any, attempt at formatting. • Simple words are used and specialist words might be present, but not used meaningfully. • Little evidence of control of tone. • Little, if any, logical sequencing or paragraphing.
0	Nothing written worthy of credit.

Spelling, punctuation and grammar	
Marks	Skills Descriptors
7 - 9	Quality of SPaG supports clear meaning. • Spelling – including some specialist words – is sufficiently correct to convey meaning. • Sentence demarcation is correct and a range of other punctuation is mostly correct. Markers to ensure smooth and efficient reading are provided. • Few grammatical errors and modality devices are used appropriately.
4 - 6	SPaG does not detract substantially from the general meaning being conveyed. • Most common/simple words are spelled correctly. • Sentence demarcation is correct and other punctuation is sometimes correct, with some markers to support reading. • Grammatical errors are present and some modality devices are incorrect.
1 - 3	SPaG errors detract from meaning. • A few examples of conventional spelling. • Little evidence of correct punctuation. • Numerous grammatical errors.
0	Nothing written worthy of credit.